

Start here

Ten minutes of setting up, and the season has somewhere to live.



You do not need to know anything about spreadsheets. You will type in the blush-pink cells and read the grey ones. That is the whole idea.

The ten minutes

- 1 Save a clean copy**
Before anything else: File, Save As, "Christmas 2026". Keep the file you downloaded untouched. It is your master.
- 2 Fill in SETTINGS**
Nine boxes: the year, the date of Christmas, when your season starts, your currency, your household name, and four thresholds you can leave alone. Everything else in the workbook reads from these.
- 3 Add people before you add gifts**
Go to PEOPLE + BUDGETS and list who you are giving to, with what you intend to spend on each. Give each one a Person ID — P-001, P-002, and so on. Gifts attach to that ID, which is how the workbook can tell you what you have spent on your mother without your having to add it up.
- 4 Decide which modules you want**
There are 35 sheets. Nobody uses all of them. TRAVEL PLAN, ADVENT + REFLECTION, MOVIES + MUSIC are optional and hide cleanly — right-click the tab and choose Hide. Nothing breaks: every total reads an empty sheet as zero.
- 5 Write five lines on SEASON VISION**
What this year is for, how it should feel, what you are protecting. It takes two minutes and it is the thing you will read in the middle of December when you are deciding whether to say yes to one more thing.
- 6 Go to the DASHBOARD**
It will tell you what is unfinished and where to go. Work down the attention board. That is the method — there is nothing else to learn.

What the colours mean

Every colour is backed by a word, so nothing depends on being able to tell two greens apart.

Colour	Name	What it means
	Blush pink	Yours to fill in.
	Soft grey	Calculates itself. Locked, so it cannot be typed over by accident.
	Amber	Either an example row you can delete, or something asking for attention.
	Deep pink	Over budget, overdue or late. The cell also says so in words.

Finding your way around

Every sheet opens with a dark green strip: Dashboard, Start here, Calendar, Budget, All sheets. SHEET INDEX lists all 35 sheets with a line on what each is for and a link straight to it. The tabs along the bottom are in the order you would use them.

The seven habits that make it work

Filter, do not delete

Every tracker has filters on its header row. Hiding what you are not working on beats deleting rows you will want in January.

Sorting is safe

IDs are typed text, not row numbers. Sort a table any way you like; nothing comes unstuck.

Adding rows

Each tracker starts with room for a set number of entries — 200 gifts, 150 orders, 200 calendar entries, and so on. If you need more, click a row in the middle of the table and insert above it, so the formulas and dropdowns come with it. Then copy one calculated cell down into the new row.

Editing the dropdowns

They all live on the LISTS sheet — 42 lists in all. To add a value, click a row inside the block and insert above it. Adding below the last value does nothing, which is the one thing worth remembering.

Unprotecting

Review, then Unprotect Sheet. There is no password. The lock exists only so a calculation is not typed over by mistake; if you want to change one, unprotect and change it.

Deleting the examples

Three amber rows on each tracker, every one marked EXAMPLE — DELETE ME. Select the contents and delete them whenever you like. The formulas beside them stay.

Printing

The dashboard is set up to print on its own as a Christmas-at-a-glance page. A tracker prints its first columns — the ones worth carrying to the shops — fitted to one page across. Filter the sheet first, or you will print every empty row. To print a whole table instead, go to Page Layout, Print Area, Clear.

How the money adds up

This is the only part worth understanding properly, because it is what makes the dashboard trustworthy.

- Every sheet that can cost money has a **Budget category** column.
- MASTER BUDGET adds up everything tagged with each category — planned in one column, actually spent in another.
- A refund only reduces what you have spent once you mark it **received**. Until then it sits on the attention board as money you are owed.
- ONLINE ORDERS deliberately does not add to the budget. The order records the parcel; the gift row records the money. Counting both would double your spending.
- If a cost is tagged with a category the budget does not recognise, it is reported on QUALITY CHECK rather than quietly dropped.

QUALITY CHECK is the sheet to open if a number ever looks wrong. Every row on it should read zero. If one does not, it names the sheet to open and what to look for.

Putting the year away

1. Save this year's workbook under its own name and leave it alone. It is the record.
2. Open your clean master copy — or, if you only have the one, copy this year's figures into ANNUAL ARCHIVE before you clear anything.
3. From MASTER BUDGET, copy the budget and actual totals. From the dashboard, gifts given and guests hosted. Paste them as values, not formulas.
4. Delete the contents of the pink cells on each tracker. Do not delete rows, and do not touch the grey columns.
5. Change the year on SETTINGS. The countdown, the calendar and every label follow it.
6. Read NEXT YEAR NOTES before you plan anything. That is what it was for.

The printable pages

There are nine of them, in the folder marked 04, in A4 and in US Letter: a cover, the season on one page, the gift list, the budget, the menu, the guest list, December on one page, cards to send, and notes for next year. Print them, or upload the PDF to Canva and change the wording first.

They are a companion to the workbook, not a substitute. Canva cannot add up a column — nothing in it calculates — so the numbers on a printed page are yours to write. The workbook is where the arithmetic lives.

Questions people ask

Can I change the colours?

Yes. Unprotect the sheet and change any fill you like. The words in the status columns are what carry the meaning, so nothing stops working.

Can I use it for a currency that is not in the list?

Yes. SETTINGS has a currency dropdown, and you can add to it on LISTS. The workbook does not convert between currencies — one workbook, one currency.

I deleted something and a cell now says #REF!

Close the file without saving and open it again. If you have already saved, the cleanest fix is to start from your master copy. This is why step one is to keep one.

Why is a category showing as over budget when I have not spent anything?

Because its budget is zero and something has been tagged to it. Set a budget for it on MASTER BUDGET, or re-tag the cost.

Can I share it with my sister?

No — the licence is for your own household. She can buy her own copy, and it will be hers to keep.